Manual Chapter : Configuring HTTP Load Balancing with Cookie Persistence

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Configuring HTTP Load Balancing with Cookie Persistence

Overview: HTTP load balancing with cookie persistence

Many computing environments want to use a BIG-IP system to intelligently manage their HTTP traffic. You can easily control your HTTP traffic by implementing a BIG-IP system feature known as an HTTP profile. An HTTP profile is a group of settings that affects the behavior of HTTP traffic. An HTTP profile defines the way that you want the system to manage HTTP traffic.

You can use the default HTTP profile, with all of its default values, or you can create a custom HTTP profile. When you create a custom HTTP profile, you not only modify the setting values, but you can enable more advanced features such as data compression of server responses.

When you configure the BIG-IP system to manage HTTP traffic, you can also implement cookie-based session persistence. ***Cookie persistence*** directs session requests to the same server based on HTTP cookies that the BIG-IP system stores in the client's browser.

Task summary for creating a basic HTTP load balancing scenario with cookie persistence

This implementation describes how to set up a basic HTTP load balancing scenario and cookie persistence, using the default HTTP profile.

Because this implementation configures HTTP load balancing and session persistence using the default HTTP, you do not need to specifically configure this profile. Instead, you simply configure some settings on the virtual server when you create it.

Creating a custom cookie persistence profile

A good way to implement cookie persistence is to create a custom cookie persistence profile.

1. On the Main tab, click **Local Traffic › Profiles › Persistence** .
   The Persistence profile list screen opens.
2. Click **Create.**
   The New Persistence Profile screen opens.
3. In the **Name** field, type a unique name for the profile.
4. From the **Persistence Type** list, select **Cookie.**
5. From the **Parent Profile** list, select **cookie.**
6. Select the **Custom** check box.
7. From the **Cookie Method** list, select **HTTP Cookie Insert.**
8. If you want the BIG-IP system to encrypt the pool name specified in the BigIPServer default cookie, select the **Default Cookie Encrypt Pool Name** check box.
9. Retain or change all other profile settings.
10. Click **Finished.**

The custom cookie persistence profile appears in the Persistence list.

Creating a pool to process HTTP traffic

You can create a pool of web servers to process HTTP requests.

1. On the Main tab, click **Local Traffic › Pools** .
   The Pool List screen opens.
2. Click **Create**.
   The New Pool screen opens.
3. In the **Name** field, type a unique name for the pool.
4. For the **Health Monitors** setting, from the **Available** list, select the **http** monitor and move the monitor to the **Active** list.
5. From the **Load Balancing Method** list, select how the system distributes traffic to members of this pool.

   The default is **Round Robin**.
6. For the **Priority Group Activation** setting, specify how to handle priority groups:
   - Select **Disabled** to disable priority groups. This is the default option.
   - Select **Less than**, and in the **Available Members** field type the minimum number of members that must remain available in each priority group in order for traffic to remain confined to that group.
7. Using the **New Members** setting, add each resource that you want to include in the pool:
   a. Type an IP address in the **Address** field.
   b. Type `80` in the **Service Port** field, or select **HTTP** from the list.
   c. (Optional) Type a priority number in the **Priority** field.
   d. Click **Add**.
8. Click **Finished**.

The new pool appears in the Pools list.

Creating a virtual server for HTTP traffic

This task creates a destination IP address for application traffic. As part of this task, you must assign the relevant pool to the virtual server.

You can also use HTTP Cookie Insert persistence with a Performance (HTTP) type of virtual server.

1. On the Main tab, click **Local Traffic › Virtual Servers** .
   The Virtual Server List screen opens.
2. Click **Create**.
   The New Virtual Server screen opens.
3. In the **Name** field, type a unique name for the virtual server.
4. For the **Destination Address/Mask** setting, confirm that the **Host** button is selected, and type the IP address in CIDR format.

   The supported format is address/prefix, where the prefix length is in bits. For example, an IPv4 address/prefix is `10.0.0.1` or `10.0.0.0/24`, and an IPv6 address/prefix is `ffe1::0020/64` or `2001:ed8:77b5:2:10:10:100:42/64`. When you use an IPv4 address without specifying a prefix, the BIG-IP system automatically uses a `/32` prefix.

   The IP address you type must be available and not in the loopback network.
5. In the **Service Port** field, type `80`, or select **HTTP** from the list.
6. From the **HTTP Profile** list, select **http**.

7. In the Resources area of the screen, from the **Default Pool** list, select the relevant pool name.
8. From the **Default Persistence Profile** list, select the name of the custom cookie profile you created earlier, such as `mycookie_profile`.
   This implements cookie persistence, using a custom cookie persistence profile.
9. Click **Finished**.

You now have a virtual server to use as a destination address for application traffic.

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